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Data Analyst Project Brief

Q1 2026 Shipment Performance Reporting Initiative

To: Business Analytics Team (Data Analyst)

From: Ifeanyi Okoro, Director of Operations

Date: July 3, 2026

Re: Cleaning and preparation of H1 2026 shipment data ahead of the Q2 Board Performance Review

1. Company Background

Meridian Freight & Logistics Ltd. (MFL) is a Lagos-headquartered logistics and freight company founded in 2014. MFL moves goods for manufacturing, FMCG, pharmaceutical, and e-commerce clients across Nigeria, combining an owned fleet of trucks and vans with contracted air cargo and river/coastal water freight partners for bulk and long-haul routes.

The business is organized around three service lines: B2B freight and haulage (the largest share of volume), e-commerce last-mile courier delivery, and a smaller specialized division handling pharmaceutical and industrial equipment moves. MFL currently tracks shipments through a Transport Management System (TMS), invoices and payments through a separate Finance/ERP module, and collects post-delivery customer feedback through a mobile delivery app.

2. Project Background & Objective

This is MFL's first attempt at building a self-service reporting layer for shipment performance, using Power Query to consolidate and standardize data before it feeds into Excel-based reporting (and eventually Power BI). Historically, performance reporting has relied on operations staff manually compiling numbers from the three source systems into ad-hoc spreadsheets ahead of each board meeting — a slow, error-prone process that the leadership team wants replaced.

You have been asked to take a first pass at the H1 2026 (January–June) shipment extract, get it into a clean and analysis-ready state, and be prepared to speak to any data quality issues you encountered along the way.

3. Data Source Notes

The attached file, MFL_Shipment_Data_H1_2026_RAW_EXPORT.xlsx, was pulled together by IT by combining exports from the three source systems referenced above:

- Transport Management System (TMS) — booking details, routing, carrier assignment, and delivery status.
- Finance / ERP module — shipment weight and dimensions at billing, cost, and payment terms.
- Delivery App — post-delivery customer satisfaction ratings.

Because there is no standardized pipeline connecting these systems today, the export was assembled manually and has not been validated or cleaned by IT. Treat it as a raw, as-is dump.

4. Scope of Work

For this first pass, please:

- Load the raw file into Power Query and review it for structural and formatting issues before doing any analysis.
- Clean and standardize the dataset: consistent data types, standardized category labels, de-duplicated records, and a clear, documented approach to missing values.
- Keep a short record of the cleaning steps you took and any judgment calls you made — this will be shared with the wider team so the process can be repeated on future extracts. P.S Keep it simply by just explaining in bulleted points what assumptions you made in your cleaning process as well as what you decided to leave and why.
- Where a value looks wrong but you're not sure whether it's an error or a legitimate edge case, flag it rather than silently changing or deleting it.

5. Data Dictionary

The extract contains 22 fields, one row per shipment record:

Column Name	Description	Expected Format / Values
Shipment_ID	Unique identifier assigned to each shipment booking.	Text — SHP-1xxxxx
Order_Date	Date the customer placed the shipping order in the TMS.	Date
Pickup_Date	Date the shipment was collected from the customer or origin point.	Date; blank if not yet collected
Delivery_Date	Date the shipment reached its final destination (or was returned).	Date; blank while In Transit or if Cancelled
Customer_Name	Name of the customer or business that booked the shipment.	Text
Customer_Type	Whether the account is a registered Business or an Individual.	Business / Individual
Origin_City	City where the shipment originated.	Text
Origin_State	Nigerian state corresponding to the origin city.	Text
Destination_City	City where the shipment was delivered.	Text
Destination_State	Nigerian state corresponding to the destination city.	Text
Mode_of_Transport	Primary mode used to move the shipment.	Road / Air / Water
Carrier_Name	Carrier responsible for executing the shipment — MFL's own fleet or a contracted partner.	Text
Vehicle_Type	Type of vehicle or vessel used.	Truck, Van, Motorbike, Cargo Plane, Barge, Cargo Vessel
Package_Category	Business category of the goods shipped.	10 categories, e.g. Electronics, FMCG, Pharmaceuticals

Package_Dimensions_cm	Package or pallet dimensions recorded at booking.	Text — Length x Width x Height, cm
Weight_kg	Shipment weight recorded at booking.	Numeric, kilograms
Distance_km	Estimated route distance between origin and destination.	Numeric, kilometers
Shipping_Cost_NGN	Total shipping cost billed to the customer.	Numeric, Nigerian Naira

Column Name	Description	Expected Format / Values
Payment_Mode	How the shipment was paid for.	Prepaid / Cash on Delivery / Credit
Delivery_Status	Status of the shipment as of the extraction date.	Delivered / In Transit / Delayed / Cancelled / Returned
Delay_Reason	Reason logged for a delay, cancellation, or return.	Text; applies only to Delayed, Cancelled, or Returned shipments
Customer_Rating	Post-delivery satisfaction rating submitted via the delivery app.	Numeric, 1 (lowest) to 5 (highest); optional

6. A Note on Data Quality

This extract has not been cleaned or validated — it is provided in the same shape it left the source systems, which is typical for a first-pass raw pull. Please don't assume any column is fully consistent. As general orientation (not an exhaustive list), you should expect things like: inconsistent capitalization and spacing in text fields, more than one date format appearing within the same column, numbers occasionally stored as text (sometimes with a unit or currency symbol attached), several different ways of representing a missing value, a handful of duplicate or near-duplicate records, and a few rows near the end of the file that are export artifacts rather than real shipment records.

Some blanks are legitimate rather than errors — for example, a shipment that is still In Transit will not yet have a Delivery_Date, and a shipment that was never delivered won't have a Customer_Rating. Try to distinguish genuine data entry gaps from fields that are correctly empty given the shipment's status.

Use your judgement, document your assumptions, and don't hesitate to flag anything you're unsure how to treat.

7. Timeline & Stakeholders

Data extracted: July 2, 2026

Board Performance Review: July 24, 2026

Data owner — bookings & tracking: Regional Operations Managers (TMS)

Data owner — cost & payment: Finance Team (ERP)

Data owner — customer ratings: Customer Experience Team (Delivery App)

Meridian Freight & Logistics Ltd. is a fictional company. This brief and its accompanying dataset were created as a training exercise for practicing data cleaning and transformation in Power Query.